

Writing for UI components

Pay attention to the intricate patterns of your existence that you take for granted. - **Doug Dillon, Writer**

A design pattern is reusable, common solution to the design problem. The goal of this guide is to create a set of UX text patterns to help establish an easy, recognizable starting place for writing consistently high-quality text.

Like other design patterns, these don't prescribe what words to use, nor should it create the impression that the pattern is needed to solve a particular problem. Sometimes, the UX text isn't the appropriate solution at all.

Guidelines for UI components include:

- Buttons and interactive text
- Text fields and text areas
- Modals & Alerts
- Snackbars
- Selection Control (Checkbox, Radio, Switch)
- Tabs
- Dropdowns
- Tooltips
- Nag Bars

Buttons and interactive text

Purpose: Allow the person to advance toward or commit to an action.

Buttons and interactive text are any text that a person interacts with tapping, clicking, or speaking to get to their next step. Sometimes they're called links, commands, calls to action; but whatever be the action, we will consider them together in this pattern.

Buttons are some of the most important text in the experience as they make the purpose known and is how people “speak” to the experience.

Buttons contain a text and/or an icon.

- The text indicates the result of clicking the button.
- The icon help visually communicate more meaning about the action.

Content guidelines

Rule 1: Use action verbs and precise diction

Always have a verb-first command. Having a generic “yes or no” makes the users read the dialog before taking an action. *Remember: The title must direct an action and the button must match that action.*

Do This 👍

[Title] Delete this campaign?

[Body] This action cannot be undone

[CTA] Cancel | Delete

Don't do this 👎

[Title] Delete this campaign?

[Body] This action cannot be undone

[CTA] Cancel | Yes

Rule 2: Use task specific language

A vague and generic button label causes uncertainty in users. They're unsure what the button will do because the label doesn't specify. Users need to know the result of their actions, and only task-specific language can do this.

To illustrate, the word "submit" is a technical term you can use for most buttons. But that would make the button labels vague and generic. When users read it, it's unclear what happens because the [label is not specific to the task](#).

Rule 3: Use the active imperative form

Too many words on a button label make users read more. **All you need to include on your button label is a verb with an adverb or direct object.** Avoid instructional terms that tell users how to use their device.

Example: Save Bulletin; Create Support Request

Do this

Read details; Download update

Don't do this

Click here for details; Yes, download the update now

Grammar

- Use title case for CTA buttons.
- Keep the CTA button to 1 - 2 words.
- Use an ampersand "&" if the CTA has 2 verbs. Example: "Save & Enable SSO."
- Avoid creating and using unique CTA buttons everywhere, use standard CTA where applicable such as when setting a DRP something. *Standard CTA buttons include:* Save; Done; Ok, Got It

Text input fields and text areas

Purpose: Help people enter accurate information

Text or form fields use UX text as labels, hints, and prefilled text for entering text, email addresses, numbers, dates, and plain text searches. Text fields are normally found within a form but can also be part of a modal, search, or card.

The best way to help people enter accurate information is to prefill the text field with the correct information. It saves times and gives the person the opportunity to correct it.

When we can't pre-fill the text field, use labels, placeholder text, or hint text field to indicate what content the person should enter.

Content guidelines

- **Placeholder text:** Lets people know how they should use the field. Always have verb-first instructions about entering information. For example: "Search," "Enter a description", "Give your campaign a name," "Enter an event description".

Alternatively, you can also give an example of the information to be entered in the text area such: "e.g. holiday campaign."

- **Hint text:** Gives context about a field's input. Use the hint text to call out any restrictions on the text field such as if the name cannot be edited later. It can also be used to providing any guidance or tip depending on the context of the workflow.

Punctuation

1. Do not use periods for placeholder text.
2. Use periods for hint text.

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Example (Bulletin creation workflow)

Placeholder text: "e.g. book release"

Hint text: Once saved, the business event name cannot be changed.

Common sentence patterns you can use for text fields and hint text include:

- Once saved, the {{thing}} name cannot be changed.
- Enter a/an {{information to be entered}}
- Give your {{feature}} a name (*When a user is naming something they have created such as a campaign, custom board, or bulletin*)

Modals and alerts

Modal and alert dialogs display content that requires user interaction, in a layer above the page. They are invasive and should be used sparingly. They require user interaction only for information or commits.

They can include critical or warning information where a response is required, however they're also intended to support efficient task completion without losing the context of the underlying page.

In some cases, modals may contain information that requires additional help and support. Elements, such as filters or hint text, can be added to the modal dialog to help users respond with clarity and efficiency at the expense of dialog real estate.

Content guidelines

- Simplify modals by removing content that does not support the task.
- Always begin the copy for the Title of a Modal with a verb; titles should use sentence case.
- The body copy should contain only valuable and relevant information that is both helpful and concise.
- Use action verbs that indicate what happens when the element is selected. For example, label a select menu with Choose a user instead of Users.

- The main action (the primary button) should reflect the modal title. An exception to this rule are generic CTA/Buttons such as “**Save.**”
- When a modal is merely informative and doesn’t seek action, the header can be a statement instead of a question. There is only one CTA in this case which is “**OK**”

Content Pattern for Alerts:

[Title] {{Desired action?}}

[Body] {{Text providing an overview of the task, and any warning info.}}

[CTA] {{Secondary Action}} {{Desired Action}}

Common sentence patterns

All data will be lost immediately. This action cannot be undone.

Example

[Title] Delete geofence?

[Body] All associated details will be removed. This action cannot be undone.

[Secondary CTA] Cancel | **[Primary CTA]** Delete

Snackbars

Snackbars are used for messages containing confirmations, alerts, and acknowledgments that require minimal user interaction. These event-driven messages appear at the top of the screen as soon as an action is completed and overlay any content. There are 3 cases in which snackbars are used:

Content guidelines

Success messages

Let the user know that they have completed an action. For these messages, it's best to reaffirm the outcome and get out of the user's way. If they have just created something, link them with an option to view it.

- Messages that appear more frequently should have less wink and be more concise.
- Messages that appear after a bigger or more infrequent action can be more playful.

Sentence pattern

{{The action that just took place}} {{the verb or outcome of the action}}

Example

Geofence deleted

Campaign saved

- **Failure messages** let the user know that something has gone wrong after they've tried to do something. These are mostly used for system errors that occur and explain the problem and provide the user with a next step or an alternative. Keep the message simple and direct, and avoid confusing the user with technical details. If it's our fault, own up to it.

Example:

An unexpected error occurred while stopping the campaign. Try again later. If this issue persists, contact support.

Maximum number of geofences added to this cluster. To continue, create a new geocluster.

- **Alert/ warning messages** appear before we request the user to take action. This is usually in anticipation of a significant change. Put yourself in the user's shoes and make sure you're not talking about something that has already occurred.

Selection control (checkbox, radio, switch)

- Use sentence case capitalization for check box, radio, and switch labels.
- All labels should be concise and provide context.
- Start all labels with a capital letter.
- Don't include punctuation after labels.

Tabs

Tabs are used to organize content by grouping similar information on the same page.

This allows content to be viewed without having to navigate away from that page.

Tab labels must provide clear and concise explanations of the content within. Each tab's content must be independently categorized and mutually exclusive of the content of other tabs.

Dropdowns

A dropdown menu displays a list of actions or options to a user. Dropdown menus are typically used when there are 5-15 items to choose from. When organizing dropdown menu items, sort the list in a logical order by putting the most selected option at the top, if known

- In general, use sentence case and write concise labels that clearly indicate the purpose of the selection.
- For action menu items, use verbs and verb phrases to describe the action that occurs when the item is chosen.

Example:

“Delete”, “Clone”, or “View DRP settings”, “Stop Campaign”

Tooltips

A tooltip is a small pop-up window that provides more information on an element under the mouse cursor. Tooltips provide additional descriptive text including formatting and icons. Tips eliminate the need to always have descriptive text on the screen.

- When writing tooltips, be short and concise and follow the writing guidelines.
- Use tips to label unlabeled controls and to provide additional information.
- Don't use tips for warnings.
- Tooltips for a disabled control should include information regarding the disabled state of the control. Include this information even if the control is enabled.
- Use tooltips sparingly.

Nag Bar

Purpose: A Nag bar stays at the top of the dashboard, till you close it. It is meant to get your attention and stay till you choose to do something about it. ..

Rule 1: A nag bar has two components; text and a call to action link (CTA)

Rule 2: Always end the Nag bar with a CTA

Rule 3: Inform the user of the situation with crisp informative language. Tell them what they must do next and lead them to the call to action.

The card set as your primary payment method has expired. To continue accessing CleverTap, update payment details